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# John Heard

*Bassist John Heard grew up in Pittsburgh and is a sought after musician both in recording sessions and at jazz festivals. His career includes stints with the Count Basie Orchestra and many small combos in the swing and classic jazz world. He currently performs with Lionel Hampton's Golden Men of Jazz and his own LA-based group The Elders.*

*John was interviewed by Michael Woods and Monk Rowe on March 4, 1995 in Scottsdale Arizona. Mary Kopcza was also present for the interview.*

MW: Greetings. We are here once again filming interviews with great American jazz artists for Hamilton College to create an archive. And we are very very flattered to have John Heard with us. My name is Dr. Michael Woods. My associate is Monk Rowe.

MR: And welcome. On our way over to the interview we had a comment from Red Holloway about how he thinks that you held that whole first session together over there today and being that the bass is such as important instrument, we wonder how you came to the bass and what attracted you to that instrument?

JH: Okay. I'll answer your first thing. Red Holloway — he lies all the time.

MR: Okay.

JH: Bass? I was in the band class one day, I think it was in ninth grade or something like that, and they needed a bass player. So he said, "You — play the bass."

MR: That was it, huh?

JH: That was it. Not very romantic, is it?

MR: Well that's okay. What was your first professional experience like, and did you think after that happened that you wanted to continue with that kind of thing? Did you want to be a musician after that?

JH: Oh I had that same kind of feeling today, it never left me — the first experience and the way it is now, it's the same.

MR: And what is it like? I mean it's like great for you?

JH: Making somebody smile or tap their foot, like move their body, want to get up and dance. That's music. Add some of the creator I guess, a little bit of that's in there, you know. But it's all about dance, shall I say, and sex.

MR: You can say that.

JH: Well you know music has — there's a lot of babies that happened by — as a result of listening to music.

MR: People associate that, that's right, with certain songs, that's right.

MW: Music is sensual.

JH: When you get older and you're married forty years, fifty years, you hear that tune that you first met your wife or whatever with, you know what I mean? You go to church, there's the music.

MW: Music is a huge part of church.

JH: That's right.

MR: What were your early playing experiences like, leading up to your experience with the Basie band.

JH: Early on, yeah, well at first, my first job was with Tommy Turrentine, who is Stanley Turrentine's older brother. And J.C. Moses was in the band, and Booker Ervin was in the band, he'd just got out of the Air Force and was on his way to the Big Apple, New York. And after that Rahsann Roland Kirk was coming through town on the way to New York so he joined this band, so I had a lot of early exposure, you know, early experiences.

MR: And what kind of people did you listen to? I mean was there guys on records that you tried to learn from?

JH: Oh, everybody. You learn from everybody. Even the ones that are terrible.

MR: You learn what not to play — I'm not going to play like that.

JH: No, I've had many experiences. Ahmad Jamal, Errol Garner, Art Blakey, Count Basie, Ella Fitzgerald, Louis Armstrong, you know, it goes on and on, Charlie Mingus, you know, and Shearing. Dave Brubeck, he had that big hit when I was in high school. Ellington, everybody. I learned from everybody, you know? Ervin, Billy Eckstine, they were all you know, they were making music in those days. They were nice times. Even Theresa Brewer and Frankie Laine, I listened to them, you know? The Four Lads, The Platters, the Dominoes, Fats Domino, all of it. Delta River Boys, right?

MR: Now you grew up where?

JH: Pittsburgh.

MR: We were talking with Red about the influence of the blues in Chicago, and Pittsburgh — what was happening in Pittsburgh when you were a kid? Was there a certain big thing in the town, or was it like just —

JH: Well you've got to realize I grew up with a huge, you know, a huge reservoir of like jazz. The institutions that came out of Pittsburgh, you know, Earl "Fatha" Hines, Mary Lou Williams, Billy Eckstine, Art Blakey, Billy Strayhorn, oh it goes on and on and on, Henry Mancini, Georgie Benson, you know, it just keeps going. So when I grew up, that's why — Paul Chambers, Ray Brown, Joe Pass, you know, so when you're playing bass a guy will come up to you and say, "Man you ain't never gonna be another Ray Brown, why don't you go home and practice" and you know that kind of stuff. That's how I grew up. Because I never had any formal education.

MR: On the instrument you mean.

JH: No. I just grew up hanging out with all that, you know, heritage from that little town. An unusual little town, you know?

MW: But that in itself is an education, isn't it?

JH: That was my education. And a lot of Pittsburgers don't know anything about, you know, math as far as music and technical things. Erroll Garner couldn't read a note. None of those people could read. So that's how we grew up. Well Pittsburgh had that thing happening anyway because of all of the corporate home offices. At that time there was the large home offices for private big businesses like Gulf and Westinghouse's home office was there, U.S. Steel, Jones & Laughlin, you had Rockwell, you had Heinz. You had 54 or 55 corporate offices at that time. And they were you know, kicking back into the town, into the arts. You know that. [I'm talking to Mary.]

MK: I learned about jazz in Pittsburgh at The Encore, listening to Harold Betters.

JH: Right, the loudest trombone player in the world, if you listen you could hear him. He had a hit, "Ram-Bunk-Shush." He had that hit, you know?

MR: I'll be darned, see?

JH: Am I lying? He's the loudest trombone player.

MK: Yes. At about 1:30, 2:00.

JH: That was in Shadyside. But I don't know if it's the same now, but several years ago I read an article about cities who put the most money into the arts. And Pittsburgh was number one on the list, you know? And where I live now was next to last, which is in Los Angeles. It has twelve million people, you know, and they don't support the arts. Not like Pittsburgh.

MR: Isn't that interesting, because they've got the whole music industry there, but they don't need to or don't feel the need to go beyond that or something.

JH: Well they've got, what is that, WPGH I think it is, where they have Mr. Rogers.

MR: Oh, the educational —

JH: Yeah, they get a lot of money for projects from the NEA. But a lot of it comes from there, you know the Carnegie Foundation and the Mellon Foundation, and the Heinz foundation. They put a lot of money into that.

MR: Can you tell us how you came to play with Count Basie, and what that experience was like?

JH: I got arrested, and the judge told me, "You spend three years with Basie or I'm sending you to the military.

MR: Wow, that's amazing. And then after that —

JH: I went to jail, no.

MR: Parole you with Ellington —

JH: Oh, Basie was great. That was probably the biggest experience and one of the nicest experiences of my life. It was a great band, a great band.

MW: What years did you play?

JH: '73 to about '75 or '76, somewhere around there. Then I went back later for about a year. First I joined Cal Tjader on the West Coast, and then Ahmad Jamal, then I went from Ahmad Jamal to Count Basie. I couldn't read music.

MR: Well that's interesting. When you get the bass book for Count Basie, what does it look like? Is it chord charts? Is it, you know — or did you learn by listening to the band?

JH: Actually I could read from the chord charts. But reading notes and things like that I wasn't very good at.

MW: But how did you catch all the kicks?

JH: I knew the music.

MR: Before you got there?

JH: When I first joined, and this is the truth, you can ask Al Grey about this, right? He was here earlier, you can ask him about this. When I first joined the band at Disneyland, I showed up and they had this book there, and I'm acting like I knew what I was doing, then so the band hits, Count Basie's like doodling as he always did, and by the way, they could tell what was coming up by the way he was doodling. So it'd be new. So I asked Al Grey, "What number?" Al say, "2-4-81" and another guy said, "5-90" and another guy said, "17." In the meantime Basie's doodling, so the band finally goes into this thing and I played it 'cause I knew the music. And that's what they wanted to know if I could do anyway.

MR: So that was your audition almost? Trial by fire, huh?

MW: But you passed.

JH: I passed.

MR: Did you do significant traveling with them?

JH: Yes, all over.

MW: Tell us about some of the times on the road with that band.

JH: I can't put anybody's, lies, if you hear anything it's all lies anyway, but, I had a wonderful time with that band. Did they tell you about the bat club? Al Grey?

MR: We heard about a court system they had.

JH: Oh Al Grey told you, oh good.

MR: But the bat system was a little different. Do you want to tell us about that?

JH: Well that's how you wound up in court. No I won't go into that. I just thought I'd leave that hanging. See that's a little bit of suspense.

MR: Well ladies and gentlemen, if you ever run into John Heard, you've got to ask—

JH: Yeah, call Buddy Tate back in. He knows it. Those were the elders in the band, see. When I was in the band I was just a youngster so I can't do that.

MR: Well Al told us quite a story about when he was the new guy and they really, you know, gave him some initiation. Was that the same with you?

JH: No I guess it wasn't. I guess it wasn't. I was kind of like an outlaw when I joined the band I guess. Because Basie would be on the road like traveling from, we'd do a gig and it would be one of those hit and run gigs, you know? You'd get those once in a while. You'd go on the way to something you'd have to drop off, play a gig and keep going. So we had this hit and run gig down in Florida. We played in Lakeland and we had to go to Fort Lauderdale or something. So Basie always had these sandwiches in store. So I'd wait until we'd go to sleep, and I'd sneak up and rip off a sandwich. It was a routine. That's the routine we had. Everybody used to crack up. So I'd be back there eating like crazy. And before I'd get it down, every time, I'd hear this noise up front [growl/grumble] and everybody'd say, "No Chief! No Chief! Don't do that to him." It was a routine every night. Every time we walked into a restaurant, we'd pull into a restaurant or something, he would have his plate there, and every time I walked by he'd start raking things in 'cause he thought I was going to — 'til I walked by. It's great. I used to call him Papa. He would bet against me, on the ping pong thing, you know the ping pong thing — I was the ping pong champion. So he would bet money that someone was going to beat me. He didn't like me winning all the time.

MR: You cost him money then.

JH: Yeah, right.

MW: But all this fun stuff kind of found its way into the music, didn't it?

JH: That's what the music was about. It was about the life we were living.

MW: Tell us about your sculpting and your painting and your art.

JH: That's my real profession.

MR: Was this something that was always part of you and you were doing —

JH: Since I was nine.

MR: Yeah? But you got into the music, and did that for a while, but now you have this —

JH: I have a whole different concept about those two. In my artwork I want to put the music and in the music I want to put the images and stuff, the colors and the textures and stuff. So I've got it all kind of turned around. But it works.

MR: Sounds like a good concept.

JH: It works, it works.

MR: And you continue to do that now?

JH: Oh yeah.

MR: How much are you playing?

JH: I'm playing enough.

MR: As much as you want?

JH: Yeah. I have a band in LA called The Elders. You'll be hearing about this band. Tootie Heath is in it, Herman Riley who works with Jimmy Smith at the moment, and Phil Wright, pianist. Herman plays reeds and Phil Wright, pianist, he's an arranger and a composer and vocalist and all that stuff. We have a great little band in LA. You'll be hearing about it.

MR: I look forward to that.

JH: It's really a great band.

MR: From the places you've been in the country, is there places you'd rather not play or places you would rather play? I mean is it pretty much the same?

JH: Magic — magic pervades all that.

MR: Yeah?

JH: Yeah. It has nothing to do with magic. Drop me off anywhere. We'll have fun.

MR: Well you ought to sell some of that then.

JH: What's that?

MR: Your magic.

JH: Oh, yeah, that's what I do every time I get on the bandstand, man, yeah, that's it. That's my concept. The dance and the magic. There's nothing else. There's no math, there's no Hindemith, and none of that crap. It's all about dance and magic, a smile.

MW: You know Aaron Copland was asked to judge a contest of twentieth century music one day. And they asked him they said, "What do you think of most of the scores that come in from the competition?" He says, "Very little of it sings or dances." I think that's what you're trying to say. It's gotta sing, it's got to dance.

JH: Yeah, that's right. It's what Ellington made remarks on one time or another.

MR: Are you a dancer?

JH: No.

MR: You move like a dancer.

JH: I can run though. No I can't dance. I mean I can clown around but I don't take it anywhere. I'm not a dancer. Maybe that's something I should work on.

MR: Yeah. On the way over you were talking about living in LA.

JH: I knew you was going to bring that up. What did you run out of questions, interesting questions?

MR: No I was interested because you know, like you said you're a pretty honest guy, and I said do you like living in LA and you said, no.

JH: Everybody there knows it too. So it's no big deal.

MR: Why do you live there?

JH: Because my wife and daughter like it.

MR: That's a good reason.

JH: That's the reason. They like it and they ain't going nowhere. So, and I'm their puppy. So I'm not going nowhere.

MR: Okay.

JH: It's not that bad.

MW: If you could call your shots, if you could live anywhere you wanted to and work anywhere you wanted to, where would it be?

JH: Work anywhere?

MW: Yeah.

JH: Well I do work all over the place, you know what I mean? I work all over. But you mean like living in a place?

MW: Uh huh.

JH: It doesn't really make any difference where you live, you know. And LA has enough talented guys out there, monsters, that you know you can get something happening. It's just the other way of life. You know I've got a huge family back east and I'd like to be around them. And LA's not a family-oriented town. So I kind of miss that.

MR: Some of our folks have been talking about Joe Williams. I wondered if Joe ever had the opportunity to play with you on the same bandstand?

JH: Joe Williams?

MR: Yeah.

JH: Yeah I recorded with him. I just worked with him not long ago. He has a great ... there is a nice album I recorded with Joe.

MR: Who else was on it?

JH: He had Benny Golson, Thad Jones, let's see who else, I can't really remember. Did he have Eddie "Lockjaw" Davis? I can't remember all the guys that was on the date but it was great. Very nice. I've done several albums with him.

MR: Have you always stuck with the acoustic bass?

JH: Yeah.

MR: Good for you.

JH: There's nothing like it, it's just what I play. I'm not in the industry, you know, I play this music. This works just fine. If it ain't broke, don't mess with it. Right? Because I try to get out of the way as much as possible.

MR: Have you got any more questions, Mike?

MW: I just would like to ask you if you wanted to leave a word with students that you knew would be watching this interview, things that you could tell them about music, to put the magic in it, what would you tell them?

JH: Well clinics don't like to hire me because what I have to say I say in about 15-20 seconds. You learn the basics and you get out in the world. You know you learn what the music's about, and that's it. It ain't about schoolwork, you know it ain't about nothing like that, you know. And if you want it bad enough you'll get it. Everybody doesn't accomplish those ends, you know what I mean? But if that's what you want to do, that's what you do. Some guys go to institutes of higher learning and they, like your Juilliards and all that stuff, and you have other guys who went there for like a month and dropped out and became legends like Miles and you know, other people, you know? So it all depends on the artist, you know? But you learn the basics and then get out of the way, you make somebody smile or tap their foot, and get up and dance. That's it. There's nothing else. Oh yeah, and you've got to put some of the creator in there. That's where it's all coming from. That's the part about getting out of the way.

MR: Great.

MK: Where's your next exhibition?

JH: I don't have any exhibitions. I just do commissions. So I'm working on myself at the moment. Someone commissioned me to do a self-portrait playing the bass, so I got this up here with the neck and the bass and my hands to here. It's turning out very nice.

MR: That's great. You get to do yourself.

JH: I'm ugly, boy. This schnoz, man, I'll tell you this schnoz is kicking the shit out of me. I like to say that.

MR: Hard to get it down, huh?

JH: There's so many different little things happening here. But it's coming. It's really looking nice. And you know I don't deal with galleries. People know what I do and they contact me and I sell, at a reasonable price, and they're getting something that's probably valuable, you know. I think an art gallery would say it would be pretty valuable. And I only do, when it has on there it's one of ten, it's one of ten. Because you can't get it anyplace else. So that has customers coming back when they know they're not getting ripped off.

MR: They've got something pretty unique, huh?

JH: Yeah. A reasonable price, too.

MR: How about your next gig?

JH: My next gig. what about it?

MR: Where is it?

JH: Where is it. It's in LA, next week with The Elders. And I guess I'm going to be working with Al Grey, Harry "Sweets" Edison, Junior Mance and a drummer, Bobby Dorn. We're going to be doing some things on the west coast.

MR: All right. Junior Mance.

JH: Oh yeah. That's going to be some fun. Talk about dance. And sex and deep fried foods and booze.

MR: Sounds like the best of the times to me.

JH: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. We're going to have fun.

MR: Well thanks for sharing your time with us.

MK: It's lively.

JH: This is probably most ridiculous, one you've done so far. Now Red Holloway, that's you know, I'm surprised you didn't end this ten minutes ago. It's boring after Red Holloway, right?

MW: No, not at all.

JH: He's a corny one. Like I say, like this lady, Rosa Lopez. Her voice says, you say hear a voice? "No," I just says "noises."

MR: All right.

JH: Is that okay?

MR: That's great.

JH: Is that okay?

MW: Yeah, that's great.

JH: How much of that you going to edit out?

MW: Nothing.

JH: Great. That's great. Don't take nothing out of there man.

MR: What you see is what you get.

JH: These people want you to behave.